India were the French, who had a presence in Pondicherry on the Coromandel Coast and Chandernagore in Bengal. The British gained the upper hand following a series of Carnatic Wars in the mid- to late-eighteenth century. [69] Such was the significance of this prize that the Comte de Lally, defeated commander of the French forces in 1760, was tried and executed for treason upon his return to France.

The mid-eighteenth century marks a major turning point for the East India Company. As retaliation against the seizure of Calcutta by the Nawab of Bengal Siraj ud-Daulah, an expeditionary force under Colonel Robert Clive was dispatched from Madras. Using a good deal of deception and bribery, Clive won the Battle of Plassey in 1757 and installed a proxy ruler, Mir Jafar. Company control of Bengal and Bihar was consolidated after the Battle of Buxar in 1764. A year later, Clive and the Mughal Emperor Shah Alam II signed the Treaty of Allahabad. This gave the Company *diwani* rights, that is the rights to collect taxes in Bengal and Bihar in exchange for tribute to the Mughal court. Two other developments further deepened Company Rule. In 1774, Warren Hastings was appointed the first British governor-general, consolidating control across the three presidencies from a capital in Calcutta. Additionally, the East India Company Act of 1784 also brought Company Rule in India under the British Government. In just a few decades in the mid-eighteenth century, the East India Company went from traders to colonial administrators. [70]

The military employment and structure of the Company is important to keep in mind when considering British expansion in India in the eighteenth and early nineteenth centuries. Each East India Company Presidency—Madras, Bombay and Calcutta—initially had its own army, which started as guard forces for their outposts. Over time, regiments of local Indian soldiers (sepoys, from the word *sipahi* for soldier) led by British officers were established, and they benefited from European drilling and training techniques. At times, these forces were supplemented by Royal regiments of the British Army, such as the 33rd Regiment, which came to be associated with the Duke of Wellington. In the century after Plassey, the Company, along with Crown forces, waged a series of wars against Indian